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Birchmore's friend tells of suspicions

Testifies she learned about Farwell's role and reported to police

By Sean Cotter and Laura Crimaldi
GLOBE STAFF

Lesley Davis recalls it as a normal phone conversation with her friend Sandra Birchmore.

It lasted about 25 minutes, the two chatting as they usually did. Now, nearly six years later, testifying in the trial of a former Stoughton police detective who is accused of killing her friend, Davis said the pregnant Birchmore never mentioned anything about killing herself, about depression, or about a potential miscarriage.

"I would have remembered, and I would have tried to do something," the 30-year-old accountant told jurors in federal court in Boston on Thursday.

Instead, when she found out a few days later that Birchmore had died, Davis remembered a different conversation with her friend. Suspicious, she drove with her mother and brother to the Canton police station and told officers about her friend's relationship with the Stoughton officer, Matthew Farwell, who Birchmore told her was the father of her baby and had pushed her to the floor in a rage just a few weeks earlier.

"I implicated Matthew Farwell," Davis said.

Davis was one of several witnesses testifying over the first three days of Farwell's trial in US District Court that they had flagged his relationship with Birchmore to local author-

FARWELL, Page A8

Title IX at center of fury about Cornell case

Statute requires colleges to protect students' rights

By Brooke Hauser
GLOBE STAFF

More than five decades ago, just 37 words banned sex-based discrimination in American schools — and transformed higher education in the process.

When President Richard Nixon signed the catch-all statute known as Title IX into law in 1972, people weren't necessarily thinking about what it would mean for women's sports, or sexual harassment on campus. But in the years since, both issues have triggered legal battles and culture wars.

Now, Title IX is at the center of the fury surrounding Cornell University, and how colleges handle allegations of sexual assault. And those 37 words have spun out into some 2,000 pages of preamble and regulations, amid an endless game of political football that seems to leave no one satisfied.

But at its heart, Title IX is about protecting civil rights for students at schools receiving federal financial assistance. "It's the job of the federal government to be there for every student, every day, to ensure that their education

TITLE IX, Page A7



JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

From left, Anna Brandenberger, Dora Woodruff, and Hanna Mularczyk called for a town hall to talk about the threat AI poses.

THE BIGGEST PROBLEM FOR MIT STUDENTS

AI is solving the unsolvable, leaving some math PhDs to reconsider their career path

By Michaela Towfighi
GLOBE STAFF

Inside the math department at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, more than 100 students, professors, and postdocs solemnly shuffled into a lecture hall, as if they were going to group therapy.

Two days before, on Sept. 8, OpenAI announced that its artificial intelligence agents solved one of the famed "Millennium Prize Problems," involving the Navier-Stokes equations, which describe how fluids move. Solutions to each problem, posed in 2000, come with a $1 million prize and celebrity status in the field.

For MIT's mathematicians, especially doctoral students, the technological milestone marked the start of a full-fledged freak-out — and they needed a forum to discuss AI. Last week, their alarm continued when OpenAI published proofs to nearly 400 additional previously unsolved problems.

It will take some time to sort out the significance, and accuracy, of these proofs. But the overarching feeling among grad students is a fear of being displaced, if not replaced.

"The personal stakes are kind of highest for us," said Dora Woodruff, a third-year math PhD student at MIT. "We're the ones who are actually going to be on the job market in a couple years. We're the ones thinking about whether we want to spend our lives in this field, dedicating [it] to this kind of work."

The upheaval comes at a time of deeper

MIT, Page A5

Delivery of new Red Line trains delayed yet again

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

The MBTA will not receive the next batch of its new Red Line trains by 2027 as expected, piling on yet another disappointment to a modernization project already years behind schedule.

The latest delay, according to T officials, is a ripple effect from the seizure of Red Line car bodies in mid-2025 by the US Customs and Border Protection at the Port of Philadelphia over suspicions they were built using forced labor.

The shells of the cars are manufactured overseas by the contractor, the China Railway Rolling Stock Corp., then shipped to the US for completion at a CRRC factory in Springfield. The customs seizure backed up production to the point where the factory in Springfield had to temporarily lay off nearly 150 workers.

"It's unfortunate that actions by the federal government have further delayed the delivery

RED LINE, Page A7

Rainy-day advice for rowers: Don't touch the water

Rain is a common issue for the Head of the Charles (right, trying to stay dry in 2023) and it tends to increase the bacteria in the river.



ERIN CLARK/GLOBE STAFF/FILE

By Kate Selig
GLOBE STAFF

The rowing crews that win their races in the annual Head of the Charles Regatta taking place this weekend may want to reconsider the time-honored tradition of tossing their victorious coxswains into the river.

▶More on the Head of the Charles, C1.

That's because there's roughly half an inch of rain forecast for Friday, the start of the celebrated three-day rowing event, which would be enough to wash bacteria and gunk from the streets into the Charles River. Even light showers drive up E. coli counts and increase the risk of harmful algal blooms. Sewage surges into the river during harsher storms.

Tremendous progress has been made to clean up the Charles, which used to be so pol-

CHARLES, Page A8

Harvard University's endowment grew to a record high of $68 billion over the last year, in a sign of resilience amid the Trump administration's legal onslaught. **B1.**

The state's Public Health Council approved rules that aim to give regulators more authority to take action against nursing home operators with poor records. **B1.**

Moist likely

Friday: On and off rain. High 69-74. Low 46-51.

Saturday: Sunny, windy. High 50-55. Low 36-41.

Sunrise: 6:58 Sunset: 6:01

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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